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Culture (OWC): [Akan \(FE12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

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Section Title(S): C. Sexual Relationships And Marriage

Another category of women is the *gyantra* (a possible corruption of the English, "gentlewoman"), also called the *ahyawwe* (taken from the Yoruba word for prostitute or promiscuous female); these ladies are usually unmarried, often have young children, and frequently have a regular source of income. These "good-time girls" spend much of their off-hours in the local bars, and they share their company and sexual favors quite freely, any charge depending upon the relationship established with the male.

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Among the Bono, it is difficult to learn who is having a sexual alliance with whom since much of this activity is kept at a private level, many relationships being held in strictest confidence. Male braggadocio as found in the American teenage context, for example, would be considered highly irregular in the Bono context. There is no strict equivalent of the Western concept of platonic love; should a male be seen conversing with a female in a public place the first assumption would be that he was attempting to arrange a sexual alliance for himself, or, more likely, for a mutual friend. Dating in the Western sense is unknown among the Bono. Sex is never indulged in publicly; one never sees males and females holding hands, kissing, petting, or having even more intimate contact in any place where they might be seen. The Western openness to such things is considered appalling to the Bono.

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The term "friend" does not translate on a one-to-one basis into Bono-Twi; its use in Ghanaian English normally refers to someone of the opposite sex with whom one has sexual relations (a person termed *mpena*); to "befriend" means to have sex with a person. The Bono-Twi term *adamfo*[*unavailable*] (usually translated into English as "friend") can be used to describe relationships between individuals of the same sex; if used by a person to describe a

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relationship with someone of the opposite sex, that person would usually be related either consanguineally or affinally in such a way that sexual intercourse between the two persons would be either taboo or considered highly deviant. In only this latter sense, involving a joking relationship, may there be platonic, "friendly" relationships between the sexes. The usual adult male-female relationship among the Bono centers upon the term *olomo*, and its synonym, *mpena*; these terms can be used to describe either partner in an unmarried, regular, ■ 33 "friendly" sexual relationship. Such a relationship may develop, of course, into one involving strong emotional ties and lead to marriage.

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